



BEFORE

The war of 1756–63 followed an eight-year conflict that had involved many of the same powers, although they did not consistently fight on the same sides.



SCHÖNBRUNN
PALACE

WAR OF THE AUSTRIAN SUCCESSION

The death of the Austrian Habsburg emperor **Charles VI** in 1740 prompted war in Europe. France and Prussia attempted to prevent his heir, **Maria Theresa**, from acceding to the Austrian throne—the summer seat of which was the Schönbrunn Palace, in Vienna—and her husband, **Francis of Lorraine**, from becoming Holy Roman Emperor. The Aix-la-Chapelle peace treaty of 1748 confirmed both Maria Theresa and her husband on their respective thrones, but left **Austria weakened** against the growing power of **Frederick II's** Prussia, which had snatched the rich province of Silesia from Austria during the war. Although the treaty formally brought peace to Europe, it also left many **issues dangerously unresolved**.

PRUSSIA EMERGES

Prussia's annexing of Silesia saw it emerge as a significant figure on the European stage, leading to diplomatic overtures from Britain and France.

COLONIAL CONFLICT

Alongside the war in Europe, Britain and France continued their **colonial rivalry** overseas. Britain captured Louisbourg on Cape Breton Island in Canada from the French in 1745, only to lose Madras in India to France the next year, although the British Royal Navy won a **number of notable victories**. The **Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle** returned both gains to their original owners, but the conflict remained intense.

The War of the Austrian Succession ended in 1748 without proper resolution (see BEFORE). Tensions over colonial possessions continued between Britain and France, while Austria plotted to regain the province of Silesia, which Frederick II of Prussia (see right) had seized in 1740.

A state of uneasy peace lasted until 1756, when Frederick signed a treaty with Britain to protect Hanover, in northwestern Germany. This powerful new alliance gave Maria Theresa of Austria an excuse for a “diplomatic revolution,” when she allied with her former enemy, France, and strengthened ties with Empress Elizabeth of Russia, to safeguard against a British and

Prussian alliance. In a preemptive strike, Frederick II marched 70,000 of his troops into Saxony, which was sandwiched between Prussia and Austria. Fighting broke out almost immediately.

Far-flung hostilities

This new conflict soon spread beyond Europe, as Austria and Prussia's allies, France and Britain, had already been battling in the Americas and East Asia. Fighting between the colonial rivals had erupted the previous year, over control of the Ohio River Valley.

In India, war broke out in 1756, when an ally of the French, the Nawab of Bengal, captured the British trading base at Calcutta, and held 145 prisoners

overnight in a small cell in Fort William: subsequent British exaggeration of the numbers held, the number of deaths, and the size of the cell turned the incident known as “the Black Hole of Calcutta” into an imperial myth.

A turning point

In Europe, Frederick had failed to achieve a decisive victory in Saxony, and found himself surrounded by hostile nations. But in June 1757 the statesman William Pitt the Elder took charge of the British war effort. Frederick won a great victory at Rossbach, in Saxony, over the French, another over the Austrians in Silesia in December, and defeated the

The First Global Conflict

For seven years, the major nations of Europe waged war not just on the European continent itself, but also, for Britain and France, in their colonial possessions overseas in the Americas and Asia. The Seven Years War was the first approximation to a world war, and gave birth to a new, truly global empire.

